DECODING PM e-VIDYA

PM E-VIDYA It was launched in 2020 to unify all efforts related to digital and on-air education to enable multi-mode access to education. The initiative includes the following components:

DIKSHA Or the Digital Infrastructure for Knowledge Sharing was a portal launched in 2017 for teachers and students. Accessible after scanning the QR code provided in NCERT books, it allows one to study any subject of their choice in 18 languages.

NISHTHA Or the National Initiative for School Heads' and Teachers' Holistic Advancement is a training programme for teachers hosted on the DIKSHA platform. Available in 11 languages.

SWAYAM The Study Webs of Active Learning for Young Aspiring Minds is an online platform that facilitates hosting of all courses taught in classrooms from Class 9 till post-graduation. Accessible by anyone, anywhere, any time. Courses are interactive and free of cost. More than 10 million enrolments till January 2021.

SWAYAM PRABHA TV A group of 34 DTH channels that telecast curriculum-based course content 24 x 7 for Class 9 up to post-graduate level. It also beams content to prepare Class 11 and 12 students for competitive examinations. There are modules for teacher training too. From the 12 channels dedicated for Class 1 to Class 12, the number will now go up to 200. Available on DD Free Dish, TATA Play, DISH TV, Airtel and Jio TV mobile app.

MUKTA VIDYA VANI A web radio for students under the National Institute of Open Schooling.

SHIKSHA VANI A podcast that uses radio/ community radio to provide content on various subjects for Classes 9 to 12.

DOORDARSHAN, ALL INDIA RADIO They beam virtual classes and educational content across the country on TV, radio and YouTube.

SPECIAL E-CONTENT Meant for visually and hearing impaired students, they have been put up on DIKSHA and NIOS website/ YouTube.

IIT PROFESSOR ASSISTED LEARNING (IITPAL) AND E-ABHYAS These provide online coaching to students preparing for the Joint Entrance Examination.

online/ on-air education to allow what is called "coherent multi-mode access" to education. Comprising several components (see *Decoding PM e-Vidya*) such as Diksha, Nishtha, Swayam, Swayam Prabha TV, Mukta Vidya Vani, Shiksha Vani, IITPAL and E-Abhyas, the programme intends to cover the entire gamut of school education, disseminated through diverse media.

Apart from the online portals, an important component of the PM e-Vidya programme is the 12 DTH channels under Swayam Prabha TV, which are meant to support and reach students who don't have access to the internet. Classified as a "one class-one TV channel" initiative, it provides curriculum-based course content for students studying under the CBSE curriculum and the National Institute of Open Schooling. It is telecast in partnership with DD Free Dish, TATA Play, DISH TV, Airtel and Jio TV mobile App on a 24 x 7 basis. Till mid-February, 1,502 live interactive sessions of 30 minutes each have been telecast for Classes 1 to 10, covering about 751 hours. For Classes 11 and 12, 149 live interactive sessions of 60 minutes each have been telecast in the same period, covering 149 hours overall.

Several educationists have hailed the government's announcement to increase the channels from 12 to 200. Sonali Jain, co-chair of the Education Committee in PHDCCI, believes that these provisions of supplementary education, emphasis on critical thinking and methodical approach will prepare students for a seamless transition from learning to practical experience. Others say the new channels will bridge India's digital divide and improve overall learning outcomes for students. "A stable internet is a persistent impediment that students from rural areas face," says Silpi Sahoo, chairperson, SAI International Education Group, Odisha. "This is where the expansion of channels will come to the rescue as most rural sections will now have access to basic study material class-wise through a DTH service on their TVs and that too in their regional languages for better understanding." A 2021 national sample survey published last year by ICRIER and LIRNEAsia, a think-tank focused on digital policy, alerted us to the fact that only 20 per cent of school-age children in India had access to remote education opportunities during the pandemic, of whom only half participated in live online classes. A study by the Azim Premji Foundation in 2020 reached a similar conclusion when it discovered that almost 60 per cent of the school children in India could not access online learning opportunities. Another study by Oxfam found that even among students in urban private schools, half the parents reported issues with internet signal and speed. A third struggled with the cost of mobile data.

Government data too corroborated the poor state of virtual education in government schools. Under the Information and Communications Technology (ICT) component of the centrally-sponsored Samagra Shiksha scheme, states are given funds for ICT Labs and digital classrooms. As per UDISE (Unified District Information System for Education) data for 2019-20, only 119,581 schools in India had internet facility and there were 65,356 ICT Labs and 29,178 digital classrooms across all government schools. The central government approved the construction of 14,868 ICT labs and 58,534 classrooms the next year. Yet, the total number of labs and digital classrooms is not even 10 per cent of the number of government schools in India—1,116,932.

Not all experts, though, are convinced about these channels compensating